NEELEY AI FORWARD — AI INNOVATION COMPETITION
EMERGING TRACK CASE STUDY

Offer Ready: A Job Search and Application Assistant for TCU Students

Teams build a tool that helps a TCU student find relevant internships or jobs and turn one base resume into applications that actually fit each role — a tailored resume, a tailored cover letter, and a clear record of what changed and why. No coding background is required — what matters is real personalization, done honestly, at a pace a busy student could keep up with.

Background

Every TCU student looking for an internship or a first job faces the same math: the postings that actually fit their background are scattered across Handshake, LinkedIn, company career pages, and more. A resume or cover letter that's been genuinely tailored to a specific posting performs better than a generic one with both applicant tracking systems (ATS) and the humans who read what gets through. But tailoring takes real time, and most students are doing this during a semester already full of classes, clubs, football games and work.

What is happening today

Students search job boards and company sites one at a time, often with inconsistent keywords, and most rely on a single static resume and cover letter that they lightly edit, if they edit it at all for each application. Career Services offers real help, but appointment slots are limited relative to the number of students applying. The result: a small number of “dream job” applications get real attention, and the rest go out mostly as-is.

Problems we're trying to solve

- **Discovery is scattered.** Relevant openings are spread across Handshake, LinkedIn, and individual company sites, so finding the postings that actually fit a student's background takes real time.
- **One-size-fits-all materials underperform.** A generic resume and cover letter are easy to filter out by ATS keyword matching and by a recruiter skimming for a specific fit.
- **Tailoring doesn't scale.** Personalizing materials for every posting is impractical by hand during a busy semester, so most students either skip it or only do it for a few applications.
- **The feedback loop is thin.** Career Services has finite appointments; many students never get a second set of eyes on a resume or cover letter before hitting submit.
- **Tracking is ad hoc.** There's rarely a clear record of what was applied to, how materials were tailored, or what's still pending a response.

What you'll work with

No internal Handshake export or TCU career-services data is provided for this case and that's intentional. The exercise is to work the way a student actually would: starting from a target role and a real resume. A few ground rules keep it honest and realistic:

- Use a real job seeker's starting point, either your own resume and target field, or a realistic stand-in profile your team creates and a target role or field (for example, “marketing internship” or “supply chain analyst”).

- Search only publicly viewable postings, company career pages and public job-board listings. Ideally, you should not have to log in to scrape Handshake or any paid job-board data.
- Never add experience, skills, dates, or qualifications that aren't true. Personalizing means reordering, re-emphasizing, and rewording real background to match a posting and not inventing qualifications the student doesn't have.
- Keep outputs in a standard, ATS-parseable format (clear section headers, no tables or graphics that a parser would choke on).

Why this is a good Emerging Track challenge

- Every student in the room has lived this problem firsthand. The case tests judgment about what to emphasize and how to search well, not a specialized technical domain.
- An AI tool like Claude can already read a job posting and a resume side by side and suggest tailored language, no coding is required, though teams comfortable with no-code automation are welcome to go further.
- The real challenge is a thin, important line: personalization has to sharpen a student's real story for a specific role without crossing into fabrication. A mistake that could get an application rejected or worse.
- It's immediately useful since the teams are building something they, their teammates, or their classmates could actually use for their own search after the weekend is over.

Minimum expectations from hackathon

Find relevant openings

- Given a target role or field, the tool should surface a shortlist of real, currently posted openings that match and pulled from public company career pages and/or public job-board listings.
- For each opening, capture the title, company, location, and the 3–5 qualifications or keywords the posting emphasizes most.
- For each opening, name the “Strongest Match” the single clearest point of fit between the student's real background and that posting, the one line a recruiter should see first.

Personalize the resume

- Starting from one base resume, produce a tailored version for at least three of the shortlisted openings, reordering and rewording existing bullet points to match each posting's language and priorities.
- Show exactly what changed between the base resume and each tailored version, and tie each change back to a specific line in that posting.

Create the cover letter

- Generate a tailored cover letter for each of the same three openings that references specific, real details from the posting and the student's actual background. It should not be a generic template with the company name swapped in.
- Flag anything in the draft the student should personalize further themselves before sending (a hiring manager's name, a specific story only they can tell).

Keep it honest and ATS-ready

- Build in a check that flags any claim in a tailored resume or cover letter that isn't actually supported by the base resume or the student's own input.
- Confirm every output follows a standard, ATS-parseable format.

AI use and build

- Ship at least one reusable AI build, a skill file, custom GPT/Claude project, prompt template, or no-code automation that could be pointed at a new student profile and a new target role and still produce useful output. A one-off chat does not count.
- Submit an AI log describing tools used, workflow, and at least one documented instance where the AI was confidently wrong (an invented accomplishment, a mismatched date, an irrelevant posting) and how the team caught it.

Final deliverable

- A pitch deck and appendix covering the shortlist for one sample student profile, the three tailored resume/cover-letter pairs with a before-and-after comparison, and the AI log, judged against the hackathon's standard rubric.

Go beyond: design for the whole job search

The tool is one part of a student's job search, not the whole process. Before you build, step back and think about the full arc: discovering a role, applying, prepping for an interview, following up, and deciding between offers.

Talk to students who've been through recruiting, or to Career Services staff, if you can. Where does the process actually break down? Where would a second set of eyes, better organization, or a well-timed nudge change the outcome?

Then ask: what tools, habits, or follow-through around this agent would make a student meaningfully more successful across an entire search not just better at one cover letter? Teams that show this broader thinking, and design something that fits into a real student's semester, will stand out. Your core requirements come first — this is where you go beyond them.

Apply creativity and critical thinking to push past the minimum: an application tracker that keeps a whole semester organized, a way to practice interview answers for a specific role, a habit that turns one good application into five. Going beyond the identified scope is where the competitive edge is.